

Duncan McAlester

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Design Systems Director with 10+ years leading the strategy, governance, and cross-functional delivery of enterprise-scale design systems. Built and scaled the Astro UX Design System from concept to a platform adopted by 200+ programs across government and Fortune 500 organizations—driving 30-50% reductions in design and development effort. Expert in defining foundational standards, establishing governance frameworks, and serving as the connective tissue between design, product, and engineering. Known for building high-performing teams, championing accessibility, and translating strategic vision into scalable systems that ship.

KEY QUALIFICATIONS

- Design System Strategy & Roadmap: 10+ years defining long-term vision, managing competing priorities, and guiding major platform evolutions
- Governance & Standards: Created compliance tiers, accessibility frameworks (WCAG, MIL-STD), and multi-product governance models adopted across 40+ programs
- People Leadership: Built and mentored teams from 3 to 25; developed senior ICs into staff-level leaders
- Technical Fluency: Deep experience with HTML/CSS/JS, Web Components, React; peer-level collaboration with engineers on implementation
- Design Tools: Expert in Figma—component libraries, variants, design tokens, and design-to-code workflows
- Accessibility: Practical WCAG implementation embedded into component lifecycle and team workflows
- Cross-Functional Partnership: Primary liaison between design, product, and engineering leadership

EXPERIENCE

DESIGN SYSTEMS MANAGER / DIRECTOR OF DESIGN SYSTEMS & PRODUCT EXPERIENCE — 2019-NOV 2025

Owned end-to-end strategy, governance, and delivery of the Astro UX Design System—the foundational platform for 60+ products across government and enterprise.

Strategy & Roadmap

- Defined and championed long-term strategic vision; guided two major platform refactors
- Led migration from CSS components to W3C Web Components for framework-agnostic adoption
- Balanced long-term platform health with immediate product delivery requirements

Governance & Standards

- Created foundational standards for visual design, interaction patterns, and content consistency
- Developed compliance tier system enabling legacy applications to align without blocking mission-critical work
- Established accessibility frameworks (WCAG AA, MIL-STD 1472) embedded into component lifecycle
- Technical Advisor to IEEE UX/UI Design Standard

Cross-Functional Partnership

- Served as primary liaison between design leadership, product management, and engineering/platform teams
- Built industry-wide community of interest connecting government agencies, contractors, and enterprise partners
- Drove system adoption metrics from 6K to 200K annual downloads

People Leadership

- Grew team from 3 to 25, forming multidisciplinary practice (visual design, UX, engineering, content, research)
- Fostered culture of systems thinking, craft excellence, and cross-discipline collaboration
- Mentored team members enabling career progression across multiple roles

Business Impact

- Secured \$6.5M in additional funding by demonstrating 30-50% reduction in customer development effort
- Enabled faster shipping cycles across 40+ programs through consistent, reusable foundations

DIRECTOR OF ENGINEERING | ROCKET COMMUNICATIONS | 2017–2019

Founded engineering department, establishing processes, hiring frameworks, and technical standards.

- Built engineering team and culture from ground up (1 to 12 engineers)
- Expanded company from design consultancy to full product delivery capability
- Balanced technical expectations with team needs, ensuring quality while elevating craft

LEAD DESIGN ENGINEER | ROCKET COMMUNICATIONS | 2015–2017

Launched Astro UX Design System, later adopted by U.S. Space Force for mission-critical operations.

- Architected core component library (20+ components), cutting front-end development time by 30%
- Built Sketch libraries and documentation systems serving as single source of truth
- Introduced docs-as-code documentation improving maintainability and developer adoption

EARLIER CAREER | 1998–2015

Foundation in UX, engineering, and product development across commercial, government and enterprise:

- Built systems adopted by 50+ U.S. Senate offices, reducing operational time by 50%
- Led product development for telemedicine service—increased profit margins by 300%
- Award-winning digital work for Disney, Toyota, Warner Bros, Sony Pictures

PUBLICATIONS

- Co-author: McAlester, Duncan. Capraro, Michelangelo. *Skip Intro: Usability and Interface Design for Macromedia Flash*, New Riders Press, 2002
- Co-author: McAlester, Duncan. Capraro, Michelangelo. *Macromedia Flash MX 2004 Magic*, New Riders Press, 2004

AWARDS

- Macromedia People's Choice Award for Branding & Corporate Identity
- Multiple Gold Mouse Awards for Best Congressional Web Site
- Multiple Silver Mouse Awards for Best Congressional Web Site
- Design System recognized externally by Dan Mall as a model of design system storytelling

SELECT SPEAKING & TEACHING ENGAGEMENTS

- Teaching (University of California [UCI], University of Nebraska Omaha [UNO], Laguna College of Art and Design): Courses in color theory, web development, and multimedia design.
- BayCHI, Bay Area Computer Human Interaction Group, XEROX PARC
- OCCHI, Orange County Computer Human Interaction Group
- FlashForward San Francisco
- FlashForward New York
- University of California at Irvine
- University of Nebraska at Omaha
- Enterprise Ground Services UX Working Group
- BMC3I Innovation Hub in Colorado Springs

EDUCATION

LAGUNA COLLEGE OF ART AND DESIGN — 1993 – 1998

Bachelor of Fine Arts